



BEFORE

Its population split between Confederate and Union sympathizers, Kentucky initially opted for neutrality. Perhaps inevitably, it was soon drawn into the conflict.

BATTLE FOR KENTUCKY

On September 3, 1861, Confederate commander Leonidas Polk entered Kentucky, taking Columbus on the Mississippi. The Union then seized Paducah and Smithland. **The state's congress called for war** against the Southern invaders, while the pro-Confederates formed an **alternative government**, recognized by the Confederacy.

Union troops took over most of the state, with the Confederate army controlling the southwest. The two clashed at Fort Donelson [see First attacks on Fort Donelson](#) and Shiloh [see The Battle of Shiloh](#). Union victories at both forced a Confederate withdrawal from most of Kentucky—their last position lost in June 1862. They were encouraged, however, when General John H. Morgan's cavalry force made a **sweep through Kentucky** in July, raiding towns and attracting recruits.



GENERAL JOHN H. MORGAN

In summer 1862, the Western Theater was a disaster for the Confederates. They had lost Nashville and western Tennessee, though they still held Vicksburg, which denied the Union control of the Mississippi. As a Union force under Major General Don Carlos Buell advanced slowly on Chattanooga, General Braxton Bragg was at Tupelo, Mississippi, trying to restore discipline and morale to his beaten men. In this grim picture, Confederate General John H. Morgan's cavalry raid on Kentucky in July shone out like a beacon of hope.

The raid prompted the idea that the Bluegrass state might be the Union's weak point, full of Southern sympathizers eager to join the Confederate ranks. In late July and early August, Bragg moved the Army of Mississippi to Chattanooga by railroad—he sent in a division at a time on a roundabout route. This maneuver contrasted with the difficulty Buell had in moving his men, his supply lines harassed by the Confederate cavalry of Morgan and Nathan Bedford Forrest.

Invading Kentucky

Installed at Chattanooga, Bragg devised a plan with Major General Edmund Kirby Smith, commander of the Army of East Tennessee.